



Men's Draw

Dark Horses

Holger Rune, Alexander Bublik, Tommy Paul, Alejandro Davidovich Fokina, and Frances Tiafoe.

Long Shots

Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard, Jiri Lehecka, Joao Fonseca, Alexei Popyrin, Flavio Cobolli.



finding the way, not understanding what to do, what for. It sounds a bit maybe dramatic or whatever, like what's the reason or purpose to live or stuff like that."

Marat Safin, a compatriot and two-time Major champion, along with a psychologist, has helped Rublev relieve "that crazy anxiety and stress." With most of his inner demons exorcised, the popular member of the ATP Player Council should finally reach his on-court potential and record some big wins.

Jannik Sinner — Hard courts accentuate Sinner's high-speed game, and he has grabbed the last three Majors on that surface. For the 23-year-old Italian, 'serve plus one' means a massive serve followed not just by a concussive forehand but the same on his backhand wing. Not surprisingly, the World No. 1 ranks No. 1 on the ATP Leaderboard in all three categories: Serve, Return of Serve, and Under Pressure. Especially impressive and relevant is his winning 88.2 per cent of tiebreaks

on all surfaces and saving 74.0 per cent of break points on hard courts.

The last time a man defended a U.S. Open singles title was in 2008, when Roger Federer won his fifth straight title. The Mighty Fed boasted more athleticism and versatility, but he faced much weaker opposition that decade than Sinner does now.

The ultimate test for Sinner once again will come in the potential final against Alcaraz. A clash of these titans almost guarantees another blockbuster.

Carlos Alcaraz — In his recently published book, *Changeover: A Young Rivalry and a New Era of Men's Tennis*, Giri Nathan captured the essence of Carlitos during the 2024 Laver Cup: "Anytime he wasn't playing tennis, he was partaking in horseplay. As much as he intimidated other players with his talent, he still remained chummy with them — hugging them, backslapping them, whispering stupid things in their ears... He was

Chasing history: Sinner will look to become the first man since Roger Federer in 2008 to defend a U.S. Open title. GETTY IMAGES

the star pupil conjoined with the class clown."

In his evolving rivalry with Sinner — where Alcaraz leads 8-5 — the star pupil will focus on how to both absorb and counteract the Italian's ferocious power. To get more weight on his shots, Carlitos added five grams of weight to the throat of his racket. A critical career stat gives him a decided edge: he is a terrific 14-1 in five-set matches compared to 6-10 for Sinner.

Now the ball is in Alcaraz's tactical court. What will he add to his vast bag of tricks to defuse and disrupt Sinner's ruthless, methodical power game? If they do meet in a 14th 'Sincaraz' duel, Alcaraz should dethrone the King of Hard Courts in another highlight-reel, five-set classic.